ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · August 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	81.8
#2	A+	Cincinnati	73.9
#3	A+	Charlotte	73.2
#4	A+	Hartford	72.9
#5	A+	Nashville	71.7
#6	A+	Kansas City	70.9
#7	A+	Salt Lake City	68.0

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Louisville	18.7
#49	C-	Chicago	27.2
#48	C-	Grand Rapids	27.6
#47	C-	Detroit	28.5
#46	C-	Sacramento	30.6
#45	C-	Richmond	31.4
#44	C	Indianapolis	34.0

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	12 cities
B+ / B / B-	19 cities
C+ / C / C-	18 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · August 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	**Raleigh** Raleigh-Cary	A+	81.8	3.1%	+3.8%	+2.6%	+0.4%	54 days
2	**Cincinnati** Cincinnati	A+	73.9	3.9%	+6.4%	+1.1%	+0.1%	40 days
3	**Charlotte** Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	73.2	3.6%	+4.7%	+1.6%	+0.3%	57 days
4	**Hartford** Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	72.9	2.7%	+4.7%	+1.9%	+2.8%	33 days
5	**Nashville** Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A+	71.7	3.3%	+6.0%	+1.6%	-0.1%	58 days
6	**Kansas City** Kansas City	A+	70.9	3.7%	+7.7%	+0.8%	+0.5%	47 days
7	**Salt Lake City** Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	68.0	3.6%	+4.2%	+2.7%	+1.0%	54 days
8	**Atlanta** Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A	65.2	3.5%	+3.1%	+0.4%	+1.9%	56 days
9	**Austin** Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	62.2	4.1%	+4.7%	+1.9%	+1.3%	67 days
10	**Orlando** Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	A-	60.7	4.6%	+5.0%	+1.4%	+1.7%	74 days
11	**St. Louis** St. Louis	A-	60.7	3.8%	+2.0%	+0.4%	+0.7%	44 days
12	**San Jose** San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	A-	59.4	4.0%	+0.3%	+1.4%	-0.6%	40 days
13	**Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh	B+	58.2	3.8%	+5.6%	+0.1%	+2.5%	50 days
14	**Las Vegas** Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	57.6	5.2%	+4.5%	+2.9%	+0.2%	57 days
15	**Memphis** Memphis	B+	57.4	4.8%	+9.0%	+0.2%	-1.4%	66 days
16	**Columbus** Columbus	B+	55.8	3.3%	+3.5%	+0.4%	-0.4%	40 days
17	**Philadelphia** Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	54.7	4.1%	+0.7%	+0.6%	+2.0%	44 days
18	**Tampa** Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	51.0	4.7%	+5.6%	+0.2%	+0.5%	72 days
19	**Baltimore** Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B	50.9	4.0%	+3.9%	-0.4%	+1.2%	39 days
20	**Seattle** Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	50.1	5.0%	+6.4%	+0.3%	-1.0%	44 days
21	**San Diego** San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B-	49.6	4.4%	+7.2%	+1.1%	-1.3%	45 days
22	**New York** New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	49.3	4.5%	+2.8%	+0.7%	+1.2%	53 days
23	**San Francisco** San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B-	49.2	4.2%	+6.2%	+0.6%	-1.6%	39 days
24	**Birmingham** Birmingham	B-	48.9	3.7%	+0.6%	+1.0%	-0.3%	58 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	**Cleveland** Cleveland	B-	47.9	3.4%	-0.3%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
26	**Dallas** Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B-	47.4	4.7%	+1.9%	+1.3%	+0.7%	54 days
27	**Boston** Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	45.3	3.9%	+3.2%	+0.4%	+2.9%	46 days
28	**Oklahoma City** Oklahoma City	B-	45.3	4.2%	+5.1%	+0.1%	-0.0%	52 days
29	**Washington DC** Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	44.9	4.1%	+5.2%	-2.4%	-1.7%	39 days
30	**Los Angeles** Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	44.7	5.0%	+3.6%	+1.8%	-2.2%	52 days
31	**Denver** Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	44.5	3.9%	+2.0%	+0.6%	-2.1%	51 days
32	**Milwaukee** Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	43.9	3.8%	+1.6%	-0.4%	+1.7%	35 days
33	**Virginia Beach** Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	41.7	4.0%	+5.9%	-0.6%	-1.1%	39 days
34	**Miami** Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	C+	41.6	3.9%	+6.9%	+0.2%	-0.1%	85 days
35	**Phoenix** Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	40.8	4.9%	+2.4%	+1.4%	-2.7%	67 days
36	**Providence** Providence-Warwick	C+	40.6	4.3%	+3.0%	+0.6%	+1.7%	38 days
37	**Houston** Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	C+	39.4	5.2%	+1.5%	+1.1%	+0.9%	50 days
38	**Jacksonville** Jacksonville	C+	39.1	4.8%	-0.7%	+0.3%	+0.8%	63 days
39	**Minneapolis** Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C+	38.6	4.4%	+0.0%	+1.5%	-1.0%	38 days
40	**Fresno** Fresno	C	36.4	7.7%	+6.0%	+1.6%	-1.7%	55 days
41	**Riverside** Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	36.3	5.3%	+6.2%	+0.7%	-1.9%	61 days
42	**Portland** Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	36.0	5.0%	+5.8%	-2.1%	-0.8%	57 days
43	**San Antonio** San Antonio-New Braunfels	C	34.0	4.8%	+1.3%	+0.6%	+0.2%	65 days
44	**Indianapolis** Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C	34.0	3.4%	-0.7%	-1.3%	+0.2%	47 days
45	**Richmond** Richmond	C-	31.4	3.8%	+2.6%	-0.7%	-0.8%	40 days
46	**Sacramento** Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C-	30.6	4.8%	+1.1%	+0.7%	-1.4%	46 days
47	**Detroit** Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	28.5	5.4%	+1.1%	-0.2%	+2.7%	39 days
48	**Grand Rapids** Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C-	27.6	4.2%	+2.0%	-0.3%	-8.8%	37 days
49	**Chicago** Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	27.2	5.3%	+3.2%	+0.1%	-0.5%	35 days
50	**Louisville** Louisville-Jefferson County	D	18.7	5.2%	+1.2%	-0.5%	+0.1%	43 days

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

81.8th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	98
Unemployment	20% weight	94
Wage Growth	15% weight	52
Cost of Living	12% weight	86
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	58
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	86
Days on Market	5% weight	62
Office Economy	3% weight	98

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+31.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	54 days	median, +3.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 81.8th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 9.41, and its low unemployment rate of 3.10%, which together signal a highly competitive job market. The labor demand is further underscored by a top-tier employment growth rate of +2.64% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +1.410% from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with an employment growth rate of +2.64% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +1.410% from its own trend, indicating that not only are jobs being added, but existing workers are also working more hours. This combination signals a strong and growing economy. The top-tier percentile rank of 98th for labor demand composite score reinforces this interpretation, suggesting a city with robust job creation and utilization.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary is 3.10%, placing it in the top tier with a 94th percentile rank, which means the job market is tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this market, being competitive with salary and benefits will be crucial.

Wage Growth

Raleigh-Cary is experiencing a year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.78%, which ranks it near the median at the 52nd percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a pace that is neither exceptionally high nor stagnant. As a result, worker purchasing power is improving, which can contribute to local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 86th, Raleigh-Cary is more affordable relative to its peers, especially considering the PSF ($217/sqft) is decreasing by -2.2% YoY relative to hourly earnings ($37.84/hr), resulting in a ratio of 5.73. This affordability advantage means that the city can attract talent without necessitating significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to balance labor costs with quality of life for their employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of +0.37% YoY, which places it near the median at the 58th percentile. Although this growth rate is not exceptionally high, it does indicate that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit slowly. This slow expansion suggests that hiring capacity is not significantly constrained by labor force growth, but it may not provide a substantial advantage in terms of an rapidly increasing talent pool.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +31.25%, ranking Raleigh-Cary in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve future affordability and accommodate workforce growth. As a result, the city is likely to remain attractive to relocating workers and businesses alike, by mitigating potential housing supply constraints.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.9%. This places the city above average in terms of housing market speed, with a 62nd percentile rank. For a worker relocating to this city, the slightly slower market means that there is a bit more time to find a home, making the relocation process somewhat less competitive and more accessible compared to extremely fast markets.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, as indicated by its top-tier percentile rank of 98th for the share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require a knowledgeable and skilled workforce. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, which require different types of specialized labor.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a highly competitive and growing economy, with a strong labor market and an attractive cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the tight job market, which may lead to challenges in hiring and upward pressure on wages, necessitating strategic approaches to talent acquisition and retention.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

73.9th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	48
Unemployment	20% weight	92
Wage Growth	15% weight	88
Cost of Living	12% weight	92
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	48
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	88
Days on Market	5% weight	88
Office Economy	3% weight	42

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+6.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+47.9%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **40 days** median, +8.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.9th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.90% and strong wage growth of +6.37% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest that Cincinnati is an attractive location for businesses looking for a skilled workforce, but may require strategic hiring and compensation planning.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +1.08% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.694% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.12, near the median. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as the city is adding jobs, but hours worked are slightly below trend. This suggests that businesses can find talent, but may need to offer competitive compensation to attract and retain workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.90%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer higher wages or benefits to attract top talent. As a result, companies may need to plan for higher labor costs and develop strategic recruitment strategies.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +6.37% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, but may increase labor costs for employers. As a result, businesses should factor in rising wages when planning their labor budgets and consider offering competitive compensation packages to attract and retain skilled workers.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living score of $192/sqft (-0.5% YoY) vs $35.18/hr, with a ratio of 5.46, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating a highly affordable city. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively low compared to other US metros. This affordability advantage can be a major draw for companies looking to relocate or expand in the city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at a rate of +0.14% year-over-year, near the median. This slow growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, but at a moderate pace. As a result, businesses may need to plan for potential labor shortages in the future, but for now, the growing labor force provides a relatively stable pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cincinnati is increasing by +47.86% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating a significant expansion of housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that the city is likely to see an increase in affordable housing options, making it more attractive to relocating workers and reducing the risk of a housing affordability crisis.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cincinnati is 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.1%, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. As a result, businesses can expect that their employees will have a relatively easy time finding housing, reducing the stress and cost associated with relocation.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's office economy is ranked near the median at the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent. The city is suited for businesses that require a mix of office and industrial skills, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool. As a result, businesses should carefully consider their talent needs before deciding to locate in Cincinnati.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and high affordability, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand. However, the city's moderate labor force growth rate and limited depth of professional talent may pose challenges for businesses with highly specialized talent needs, and decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering Cincinnati as a potential location. Overall, Cincinnati's strengths make it a compelling choice for businesses that can adapt to its labor market dynamics.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A+

EXCELLENT

73.2th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	92
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	60
Cost of Living	12% weight	76
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	56
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	40
Days on Market	5% weight	60
Office Economy	3% weight	78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-5.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	57 days	median, +7.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.2th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 7.47, and its low unemployment rate of 3.60%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of a 1.57% employment growth rate and a 0.970% weekly hours deviation from trend also underscores the city's genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has seen a 1.57% employment growth rate year-over-year, coupled with a 0.970% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a thriving economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.47 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia stands at 3.60%, which is in the top tier, indicating a tight labor market with minimal slack. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may need to be more aggressive in its recruitment efforts.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 4.70%, which is above average, ranking in the 60th percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. The implication for employer labor costs is that they will need to budget for higher wages, while workers will benefit from increased earning potential.

Cost of Living

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a cost of living score that places it in the 76th percentile, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. With a price per square foot of $220 and average hourly earnings of $38.03, the ratio of 5.78 is relatively favorable. This affordability advantage means that the city can attract talent without necessarily having to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has grown by 0.33% year-over-year, which is near the median. This slow growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, but at a modest pace. The implication for hiring capacity is that while the labor pool is not shrinking, it is not growing rapidly either, which may limit the city's ability to support very rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has decreased by 5.10% year-over-year, which is near the median but on the lower side. This decline suggests that housing supply is not expanding as quickly as it could be, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation is cautionary, indicating potential tightening in the housing market.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.5%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city as it may provide them with more time to find suitable housing. However, the market is still relatively competitive, and relocating workers should be prepared to act fairly quickly when finding a home.

Office Economy

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 78th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, which require different types of workforce skills.

The bottom line for a business considering Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is that the city offers a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a tight but not impossible hiring environment, and an affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the potential for future housing affordability issues due to the decline in residential building permits, which could impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent over the long term.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #4 OF 50

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

72.9th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	84
Unemployment	20% weight	98
Wage Growth	15% weight	62
Cost of Living	12% weight	35
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	96
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	78
Days on Market	5% weight	4
Office Economy	3% weight	40

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **2.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+18.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **33 days** median, -2.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 72.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.70% and its strong labor force growth of +2.77% YoY, signaling a highly competitive job market. The labor demand composite score of 6.34, combining employment growth of +1.88% and a slight decline in weekly hours, suggests genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.88% and weekly hours deviation of -0.593% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs while hours worked are slightly below trend. This combination signals that the labor market is robust, with employers hiring more workers even if they are not requiring them to work as many hours as before. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 reinforces this interpretation, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is exceptionally low, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, potentially driving up wages and making it harder to staff open positions. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have strong bargaining power, which could impact business labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.73% is above average, ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but workers are also experiencing increased purchasing power. As wages grow, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive in the market.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Hartford, with a PSF of $253/sqft and average hourly earnings of $39.99, results in a ratio of 6.33, ranking below average in the 35th percentile. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The rising PSF, increasing by 4.1% YoY, further exacerbates the affordability concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.77% YoY, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile, suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a growing pool of potential employees. Businesses can capitalize on this trend to find and recruit new talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +18.05%, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This above-average growth rate, ranking in the 78th percentile, signals that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to increase, improving affordability and accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 33 days, with a year-over-year decline of -2.9%, indicating a highly competitive and fast-paced housing market. This bottom-tier ranking of 4th percentile means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. Businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or adjust their hiring timelines to account for this competitive market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.14, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent in these sectors. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized office or tech talent.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with strong labor force growth and low unemployment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent. Despite this challenge, the city's overall economic character and growing housing supply make it an attractive location for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #5 OF 50

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A+

EXCELLENT

71.7th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	86
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	82
Cost of Living	12% weight	65
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	40
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	40
Days on Market	5% weight	44
Office Economy	3% weight	88

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-5.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	58 days	median, +5.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking at the 71.7th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with an 86th percentile ranking, and its strong wage growth, at +5.97% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a robust job market and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

Nashville's employment growth rate is +1.56% year-over-year, combined with a -0.141% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in slightly fewer hours than the trend, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further supports this, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville is 3.30%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate puts upward pressure on wages. With a tight market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Nashville is +5.97% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees see their earnings increase. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses, as rising labor costs can eat into profit margins.

Cost of Living

Nashville's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 65, and a price-to-salary ratio of $260/sqft to $35.48/hr, or 7.33 above average. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.8% year-over-year further supports the city's affordability. This means that Nashville has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live in the city without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This slow growth rate may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is not expanding rapidly. Businesses may need to be strategic in their recruitment efforts to attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Nashville is decreasing by -5.10% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decrease in permits may signal future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Nashville is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.5%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market for relocating workers, as homes are taking slightly longer to sell. However, the market is still relatively accessible, and workers should be able to find housing within a reasonable timeframe.

Office Economy

Nashville's professional talent pool is deep, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, with a strong share of jobs in office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a knowledgeable and skilled workforce. However, it may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Nashville offers businesses a strong labor market, with genuine demand expansion and rising wages, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a skilled and growing workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may pose future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, requiring businesses to factor this into their location decision and talent attraction strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

70.9th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	72
Unemployment	20% weight	80
Wage Growth	15% weight	96
Cost of Living	12% weight	84
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	60
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Days on Market	5% weight	14
Office Economy	3% weight	24

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-1.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	47 days	median, -2.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.9th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.77, and its top-tier wage growth of 7.70% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and rising earnings.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate of 0.84% year-over-year, combined with a 0.296% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicates genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The combination of these metrics suggests a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.70% is relatively low, ranking it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.70%, Kansas City is experiencing rapid earnings increases, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This fast wage growth will lead to rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers will have increased purchasing power, benefiting local businesses. Companies should factor in these rising labor costs when considering a location in Kansas City.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 84th, indicating that it is more affordable than most of its peer cities. The city's PSF of $197/sqft, although rising 2.1% year-over-year, combined with an hourly wage of $35.67, results in a ratio of 5.52. This affordability advantage will be a talent attraction benefit for businesses, as they won't need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of 0.50% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that businesses will have a growing pool of potential employees to draw from, making it easier to hire and expand operations.

Building Permits

The city's residential building permits have decreased by 1.26% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 50th percentile. This decline in permits may signal a tightening of the housing supply, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation. Businesses should consider the potential long-term implications of this trend on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

Homes in Kansas City are currently selling at a median of 47 days on market, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.1%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. Businesses should be prepared to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to help new employees navigate this competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in specialized roles, making it less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. However, the city may still be a good fit for companies in other industries, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a strong labor market with rising earnings, a relatively affordable cost of living, and an expanding workforce supply. However, the city's tight labor market and competitive housing market may pose challenges for companies looking to hire and attract talent, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating Kansas City as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A+

EXCELLENT

68.0th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	90
Unemployment	20% weight	80
Wage Growth	15% weight	56
Cost of Living	12% weight	53
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	72
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	16
Days on Market	5% weight	62
Office Economy	3% weight	96

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-21.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	54 days	median, +3.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Salt Lake City-Murray has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.0th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 90th percentile, and its high share of office and professional workers, ranking in the 96th percentile. Specifically, the city's employment growth rate of 2.73% and hours deviation of -0.912% signal a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate of 2.73% and hours deviation of -0.912% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs at a rapid pace, and while hours worked are slightly below trend, it suggests that the workforce is absorbing the new demand without significant strain. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 3.60%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. With an unemployment rate in the 80th percentile, businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, which could lead to upward pressure on wages. However, this also suggests a strong and stable local economy.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 4.19%, which is moderate and ranks in the 56th percentile. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. Additionally, workers in the area are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Salt Lake City-Murray has a cost of living score in the 53rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $265/sqft to $38.98/hr, or 6.80. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, although the ratio is rising by 1.1% year-over-year. The moderate affordability of the city makes it an attractive location for businesses looking to recruit talent without having to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray is growing at a rate of 0.96% year-over-year, which is above average and ranks in the 72nd percentile. This expansion of the labor force supply suggests that businesses will have a growing pool of potential workers to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Salt Lake City-Murray has decreased by 21.89% year-over-year, which is a significant decline and ranks in the 16th percentile. This reduction in housing supply could lead to tighter market conditions and decreased affordability in the future, potentially making it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.9%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing slightly, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the market remains relatively competitive, and businesses may still need to consider housing support or relocation assistance for new hires.

Office Economy

Salt Lake City-Murray has a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking in the 96th percentile. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Salt Lake City-Murray offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a tight but stable unemployment rate, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the decline in residential building permits, which could lead to future affordability and housing supply challenges for relocating workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A

VERY GOOD

65.2th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	70
Unemployment	20% weight	72
Wage Growth	15% weight	42
Cost of Living	12% weight	55
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	88
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	72
Days on Market	5% weight	50
Office Economy	3% weight	64

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+3.1%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.4%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+1.9%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+15.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
56 days
median, +3.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and labor force growth being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, at 70th and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.66 and labor force growth rate of +1.93% YoY signal a robust job market. With an employment growth rate of +0.41% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.789%, Atlanta's economy is characterized by genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.41% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.789% indicate that Atlanta is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours worked above the trend. This combination suggests that the city's economy is growing, and businesses are likely to face increasing demand for their products or services. The labor demand composite score of 5.66 further reinforces this notion, placing Atlanta in the 70th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta stands at 3.50%, which is in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and wage pressure may be higher. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is strong, driven by a large and employed population.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Atlanta is +3.15%, placing the city in the 42nd percentile, which is near the median. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power. This balance is likely to support a stable business environment.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 55th, Atlanta is relatively affordable, considering its PSF of $197/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.71, resulting in a ratio of 5.37. This affordability is likely to be a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a decent standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums. The stable YoY change in PSF (+0.0%) also contributes to the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +1.93% YoY, placing the city in the 88th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a larger pool of potential employees. The growing labor force also implies that Atlanta is likely to maintain its economic momentum.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +15.16%, indicating that housing supply is expanding. This growth in building permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which should help maintain affordability and support workforce accommodation. The 72nd percentile rank further reinforces this positive outlook.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Atlanta is 56 days, with a YoY increase of +3.7%. This suggests that the housing market is normalizing, becoming slightly less competitive for buyers. For workers relocating to Atlanta, this means that the market is becoming more accessible, with homes taking a bit longer to sell, providing more options and potentially better prices.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 64th, Atlanta has a deep professional talent pool, making it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. The city's share of professional and office workers is 3.06, indicating a strong presence of specialized roles. However, this also means that Atlanta may not be the best fit for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, growing workforce, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the relatively tight labor market and moderate wage growth rate may pose challenges for businesses in terms of hiring and labor costs, which decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this city as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A-

GOOD

62.2th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	88
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	64
Cost of Living	12% weight	96
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	78
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	2
Days on Market	5% weight	22
Office Economy	3% weight	94

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-37.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	67 days	median, +1.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 62.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 88th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 96th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.89% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.596% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.89% employment growth rate and a -0.596% deviation in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend despite job growth. This indicates that the labor market is experiencing organic growth rather than a survivor squeeze. The top-tier labor demand composite score of 6.35 further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 4.10%, ranking at the 36th percentile, which suggests that the market has some slack. This implies that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire in this market compared to tighter labor markets. However, the unemployment rate is not so low that it would drive significant wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 4.74%, ranking above average at the 64th percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. This could be beneficial for businesses that rely on a skilled and motivated workforce.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $234/sqft to $37.55/hr, and a -8.6% year-over-year change in PSF, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is highly affordable, ranking at the 96th percentile. This means that the city has a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a high quality of life without requiring substantial wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.27% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This expanding labor force supply implies that businesses have a growing pool of potential employees to hire from, making it easier to scale operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -37.80%, ranking at the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 67 days, with a 1.5% year-over-year increase. This relatively slow market, ranking at the 22nd percentile, means that workers relocating to this city may find it more accessible to purchase or rent a home, as there is less competition.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked at the 94th percentile, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy roles, but may be less ideal for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-based workforces.

In conclusion, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #10 OF 50

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

A-

GOOD

60.7th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	82
Unemployment	20% weight	22
Wage Growth	15% weight	66
Cost of Living	12% weight	82
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	84
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	20
Days on Market	5% weight	58
Office Economy	3% weight	92

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-17.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	74 days	median, -1.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 60.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, and its high share of office and professional workers, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. Specifically, the city's employment growth rate of +1.39% and weekly hours deviation of +0.025% signal a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.39% and weekly hours deviation of +0.025% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than the 12-month trend, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.27 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.60% is below average, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies that workers may have more bargaining power, potentially driving up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.04% is above average, ranking in the 66th percentile, indicating a moderate to fast pace of wage increases. This suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but workers are also experiencing an increase in purchasing power. The relatively strong wage growth may attract workers to the area, but it also poses a challenge for businesses looking to manage labor costs.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $223/sqft to $33.41/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of -3.0% in PSF, the city ranks in the top tier at the 82nd percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability, making it an advantageous location for businesses looking to attract workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.74% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. The increasing labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to grow in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -17.79%, ranking below average at the 20th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This suggests that the city may face challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially leading to increased housing costs and decreased affordability. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain workers in the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 74 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.3%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may face a moderately competitive housing market, but still have a reasonable chance of finding a home.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share of 4.08, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, the city has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces. The strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and knowledgeable workforce.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, a growing workforce supply, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to increased housing costs and decreased affordability, potentially impacting the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

St. Louis

St. Louis

A-

GOOD

60.7th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	62
Unemployment	20% weight	78
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	71
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	64
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	76
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	42

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+16.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	44 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 60.7th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.59, and its low unemployment rate of 3.80%, which ranks it at the 78th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a strong job market and limited labor supply slack.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is +0.44% year-over-year, combined with a +0.672% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month trend. This signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is experiencing an increase in workload without relying on survivor squeeze. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the city.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.80%, ranking it at the 78th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. As a result, wage pressure is likely to be higher in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in St. Louis is +2.03%, which ranks it at the 30th percentile, indicating moderate to slow wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a relatively slow pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. As a result, businesses may need to balance the need to attract and retain talent with the need to manage labor costs.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living percentile rank of 71, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities, with a PSF of $164/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.27/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.40. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living in the city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.69% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This is a positive sign for businesses, as it suggests that the labor pool is growing, and hiring capacity is increasing. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent in the city.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in St. Louis is increasing by +16.20% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence, and future housing affordability is likely to improve, making it easier for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in St. Louis is 44 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. This means that workers relocating to the city may face a competitive housing market, and businesses may need to consider this when making relocation or hiring decisions.

Office Economy

St. Louis has an office economy percentile rank of 42, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool, with a share of 2.18 out of 5. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional roles, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a strong job market, limited labor supply slack, and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to expand or establish operations. However, the city's slow wage growth and competitive housing market may pose challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent, and decision-makers should factor these constraints into their location decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

A-

GOOD

59.4th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	94
Unemployment	20% weight	72
Wage Growth	15% weight	8
Cost of Living	12% weight	4
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	32
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	98
Days on Market	5% weight	88
Office Economy	3% weight	82

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.0%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.3%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+132.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **40 days** median, +8.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 59.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier percentile rank of 94th, and its extremely high cost of living, ranking at only the 4th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an employment growth rate of +1.44% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of +1.369% from its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a strong increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The top-tier percentile rank of 94th for labor demand composite score further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 4.00%, ranking at the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the limited availability of workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is +0.27%, ranking at a low 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth may keep labor costs flat for employers, but it also means that workers have limited bargaining power and may not see significant increases in their purchasing power. The low wage growth rate may be a concern for businesses that rely on attracting and retaining top talent.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living percentile rank of only 4th, with a PSF of $797/sqft and average hourly earnings of $53.33/hr, resulting in a ratio of 14.94. This indicates that the city is extremely expensive relative to peers, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums. The high cost of living may be a major constraint for businesses considering relocation to this area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a year-over-year growth rate of -0.60%, ranking at the 32nd percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. The declining labor force growth rate may limit the city's ability to support long-term business growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is +132.71%, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is expected to increase, which may improve affordability and support workforce accommodation. The rapid growth in building permits is a positive sign for businesses concerned about housing costs and availability.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.1%, ranking at the 88th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which may be more accessible for workers relocating to the area. The rising days on market may signal a healthy normalization of the housing market, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Office Economy

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 82nd. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy sectors. However, the city's extremely high cost of living and stagnant wage growth may create significant challenges for businesses trying to attract and retain talent, and may require significant wage premiums to compensate. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which may limit the city's ability to support long-term business growth and talent attraction.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #13 OF 50

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

58.2th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	26
Unemployment	20% weight	84
Wage Growth	15% weight	74
Cost of Living	12% weight	51
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	92
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	66
Days on Market	5% weight	16
Office Economy	3% weight	36

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+13.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, -2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.2th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.80% and its above-average wage growth of 5.61%. These metrics suggest a tight labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is 0.06% year-over-year, and its weekly hours are deviating -0.272% from its own 12-month trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.11, which ranks below average at the 26th percentile. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend despite job growth. The scenario is more indicative of a stable but not expanding labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.80%, ranking at the 84th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, hiring may be challenging, and companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract workers.

Wage Growth

Pittsburgh experiences above-average wage growth of 5.61% year-over-year, ranking at the 74th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also increases worker purchasing power. As wages continue to rise, businesses should anticipate higher labor expenses, but the local workforce will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $174/sqft to $32.99/hr, Pittsburgh ranks at the 51st percentile in terms of affordability. This near-median ranking suggests that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive compared to its peers. The cost of living is relatively stable, with PSF increasing by 1.8% year-over-year, which may not require significant wage premiums to attract talent but also does not offer a substantial advantage in this regard.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 2.55% year-over-year, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

Pittsburgh sees a 13.14% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking above average at the 66th percentile. This rise in permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in Pittsburgh currently sit on the market for a median of 50 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.0%. This relatively fast market, ranking at the 16th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks below average at the 36th percentile. This suggests that while there is some depth to the professional talent pool, the city may not be as well-suited for businesses requiring a large number of specialized, knowledge-economy workers, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market with rising wages and an expanding workforce, suggesting both opportunities and challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the competitive labor market, which may drive up wage costs but also indicates a skilled and productive workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

57.6th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	96
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	58
Cost of Living	12% weight	61
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	0
Days on Market	5% weight	56
Office Economy	3% weight	86

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-39.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	57 days	median, +5.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 57.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with a composite score of 8.57, and its strong office economy, ranking at the 86th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 2.93% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.171% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 2.93% employment growth rate and a 0.171% increase in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area. This indicates that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The top-tier labor demand composite score of 8.57 further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas stands at 5.20%, ranking at the 36th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still a notable pool of potential employees available. For a business trying to hire in this market, the relatively higher unemployment rate compared to other metros could mean less wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 4.53%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is also on the rise. This balance could be attractive for businesses looking to manage labor expenses while still offering competitive compensation.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $262/sqft to $33.03/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 2.2% in PSF, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas ranks at the 61st percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, which could be a significant talent attraction advantage without needing to offer substantial wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has grown by 0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This slow but positive growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit at a modest pace. For businesses, this means that while hiring capacity is not significantly constrained by labor force growth, it also does not offer a rapidly expanding pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits has decreased by 38.98%, ranking at the bottom tier. This sharp decline signals that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend is a significant concern for businesses considering relocation or expansion in the area.

Days on Market

Homes in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas currently sit on the market for a median of 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.6%. This suggests a slightly slower market, which could be more accessible for relocating workers. However, the near-median percentile rank of 56th indicates that the market is not excessively slow or fast, offering a relatively balanced environment for both buyers and sellers.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking at the 86th percentile, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas offers a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which signals potential future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating workforce growth. This could offset some of the city's advantages and should be carefully considered in any relocation or expansion decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

Memphis

Memphis

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

57.4th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	66
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	98
Cost of Living	12% weight	98
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	18
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	48
Days on Market	5% weight	10
Office Economy	3% weight	6

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+9.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-1.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	66 days	median, +8.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 57.4th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally high wage growth rate of 9.02% year-over-year and its top-tier cost of living score, with a PSF to wages ratio of 4.58, driven by a 6.1% year-over-year decrease in PSF to $154/sqft. These metrics suggest a city with strong labor market dynamics and an attractive affordability profile.

Labor Demand

Memphis exhibits a labor demand composite score of 5.65, driven by employment growth of 0.22% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.041% above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The city's labor market is thus characterized by a robust and increasing need for workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis stands at 4.80%, ranking it below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight. For a business trying to hire in Memphis, this means there is a somewhat easier time finding candidates compared to tighter labor markets, but still with some wage pressure.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 9.02%, Memphis is experiencing very fast wage growth, ranking it at the 98th percentile. This rapid increase in wages implies rising labor costs for employers but also enhances worker purchasing power, contributing to a stronger local economy.

Cost of Living

Memphis is highly affordable, with a cost of living score ranking it at the 98th percentile. The city's PSF to wages ratio of 4.58, combined with a 6.1% year-over-year decrease in PSF to $154/sqft, makes it an attractive location for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums. This affordability is a considerable advantage for talent attraction and retention.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is shrinking at a rate of -1.37% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing, which could challenge businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Memphis are decreasing by 1.49% year-over-year, suggesting a tightening in future housing supply. This decrease signals potential future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

Homes in Memphis are currently sitting on the market for 66 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.2%. This longer days on market figure, ranking at the 10th percentile, indicates a slower market that is more accessible for relocating workers, as they have more time to find and secure a home.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking at the 6th percentile in terms of the share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth, exceptional affordability, and a labor market with some slack, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which poses significant challenges for hiring and workforce expansion, and necessitates careful planning and strategy to overcome.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #16 OF 50

Columbus

Columbus

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.8th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	52
Unemployment	20% weight	96
Wage Growth	15% weight	48
Cost of Living	12% weight	59
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	36
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	10
Days on Market	5% weight	84
Office Economy	3% weight	16

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-25.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	40 days	median, +5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B+ and a composite score ranking it at the 55.8th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.30% and a near-median labor demand composite score of 5.16. The city's economic character is most defined by its tight labor market and moderate labor demand growth, with employment growing at a rate of +0.44% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a strong but not overheating economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.44% and hours deviation of +0.246% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a moderate increase in labor demand, with businesses adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.16, ranking at the 52nd percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.30% ranks at the 96th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Columbus may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.49% ranks at the 48th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are experiencing a decent increase in purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the benefits of a moderately growing workforce.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.03, based on $207/sqft and $34.31/hr, Columbus ranks at the 59th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The stable year-over-year change in PSF (+0.0% YoY) also contributes to the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.43% year-over-year, ranking at the 36th percentile. This decline in labor force growth indicates that the supply of workers is shrinking, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -25.53%, ranking at the 10th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that the city's housing market may become less affordable in the future, potentially affecting workforce accommodation and attraction. As a result, businesses may need to factor in the potential for increased housing costs when considering relocation or expansion.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.3%, ranking at the 84th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to Columbus, this may mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, allowing them to find suitable housing at a relatively leisurely pace.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share ranking at the 16th percentile, Columbus has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a business a relatively affordable and moderately growing economy, with a tight labor market and moderate labor demand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which may pose challenges for hiring and workforce accommodation in the future.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #17 OF 50

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

B

AVERAGE

54.7th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	68
Unemployment	20% weight	72
Wage Growth	15% weight	12
Cost of Living	12% weight	24
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	90
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	68
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+0.7%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+2.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+14.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
44 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and labor force growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.65, combining a +0.61% employment growth rate and a +0.496% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its labor force growth rate of +2.00% YoY indicates an expanding workforce supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.61% and weekly hours deviation of +0.496% from its own trend suggest that Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours running above trend. This combination indicates a strong labor market where businesses can find workers to meet increasing demand. The labor demand composite score of 5.65 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the 68th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.10% is relatively low, ranking in the 72nd percentile, which means the job market is tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, potentially leading to wage pressure as companies compete for a limited pool of qualified workers. However, it also suggests a skilled and engaged workforce.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.68% is relatively slow, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean a more stable labor cost environment but may also reflect a less dynamic local economy.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $231/sqft to $32.52/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.10, and ranking in the 24th percentile, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This expense, combined with a stable PSF YoY change, suggests that the city may not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums, as the cost of living is higher than in many other metros.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.00% YoY, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth is beneficial for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, with more potential workers entering or already in the labor market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +14.19%, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to better affordability and easier workforce accommodation in the long term.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for 44 days, with a 0% YoY change, placing the city in the 26th percentile. This relatively fast market means that relocating workers may face a competitive environment when looking for housing, potentially making it tougher for businesses to attract talent due to the swift pace of home sales.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score ranking near the median (50th percentile), Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a moderately deep talent pool suited for professional and office sectors. This makes the city a viable location for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, though it may not stand out as a leader in these areas compared to other metros.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro offers businesses a combination of growing labor demand and an expanding labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and grow. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively slow wage growth, which, while keeping labor costs stable, may also indicate a less dynamic local economy with weaker worker purchasing power.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

B

AVERAGE

51.0th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	50
Unemployment	20% weight	14
Wage Growth	15% weight	72
Cost of Living	12% weight	90
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	62
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	30
Days on Market	5% weight	54
Office Economy	3% weight	74

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+5.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.5%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-9.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
72 days
median, -1.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 51.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average wage growth and highly affordable cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by a wage growth rate of 5.58% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of $236/sqft to $37.30/hr, resulting in a top-tier affordability score. These metrics suggest a city with a strong labor market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 0.23% year-over-year, combined with a 0.504% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score of 5.13. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The city's labor market is adding jobs and hours are running above trend, suggesting a healthy environment for businesses.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with upward pressure on wages. In practical terms, companies looking to staff up in this city may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 5.58%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, while also benefiting from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living ratio of $236/sqft to $37.30/hr, with a top-tier affordability score at the 90th percentile. This means that the city is highly affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive destination for talent without requiring wage premiums. The city's affordability advantage can be a major draw for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of 0.52% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This positive growth rate indicates an expanding workforce supply, which can support hiring capacity and business growth. As the labor force continues to grow, businesses can tap into a increasing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has decreased by 9.95% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This decline in permits suggests a tightening housing supply, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation. This trend may pose a risk to the city's attractiveness for relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 72 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.4%. This near-median days on market suggests a relatively competitive housing market, which can be challenging for relocating workers. However, the decreasing trend in days on market may indicate a normalization of the market, making it more accessible for newcomers.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a professional and office worker share of 3.20, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordable living costs, and a growing labor force, making it an attractive destination for relocation or expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the declining number of residential building permits, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation, potentially undermining the city's attractiveness for businesses and workers alike.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

B

AVERAGE

50.9th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	14
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	54
Cost of Living	12% weight	88
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	44
Days on Market	5% weight	86
Office Economy	3% weight	22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-2.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, +5.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its high cost of living affordability and labor force growth. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.78, and its high affordability, with a cost of living ratio of $216/sqft to $36.97/hr, ranking in the 88th percentile. This unique combination signals a city with a relatively slow job market but attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.37% year-over-year, combined with a -0.648% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This signals a scenario where the city is experiencing a genuine demand contraction, rather than a survivor squeeze, as both jobs and hours are declining. The low labor demand composite score of 3.78, ranking in the 14th percentile, reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.00%, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +3.93%, ranking in the 54th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but not excessively, and that workers are experiencing some increase in purchasing power. The moderate wage growth may help attract and retain workers, but may not be sufficient to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living ratio of $216/sqft to $36.97/hr, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.3% in PSF, ranking in the 88th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs. The affordability advantage can be a talent attraction strategy.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of +1.23% year-over-year, ranking in the 74th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the pool of available workers is increasing. Businesses may find it easier to staff their operations in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -2.81%, ranking in the 44th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The decrease in permits may lead to increased competition for available housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.4%, ranking in the 86th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it a more accessible and less competitive environment for workers relocating to the city. The increase in days on market may signal a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a professional and office worker share of 1.66, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is better suited for businesses that are not heavily reliant on professional or office workers, such as industrial or logistics companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and labor force growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand, which may limit the pool of available workers and hinder economic expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

50.1th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	38
Unemployment	20% weight	20
Wage Growth	15% weight	88
Cost of Living	12% weight	39
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	26
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	94
Days on Market	5% weight	92
Office Economy	3% weight	72

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
5.0%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+6.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.3%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+91.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
44 days
median, +10.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 6.37% year-over-year and its significant increase in building permits, up 91.03% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy and increasing housing supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 0.27% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.048% above its own trend, indicating a moderate labor demand expansion. This combination signals genuine demand for labor, although at a slower pace than many other metros. The labor demand composite score of 4.73 places the city in the 38th percentile, below average.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.00%, placing it in the 20th percentile, which means the market has some slack. This rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still a pool of available workers, mitigating some of the wage pressure seen in tighter labor markets. For a business trying to hire, this means there is a manageable level of competition for talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.37%, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue experiences fast wage growth, ranking in the 88th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand. Businesses should factor in these increasing labor costs when considering relocation or expansion.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score that places it in the 39th percentile, indicating it is below average in terms of affordability, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $438/sqft to $47.26/hr, or 9.27. Although the PSF is falling by 2.2% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This expense means businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's high cost of living could be a deterrent without them.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is contracting at a rate of -0.96% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses should be aware that finding and retaining talent may become increasingly challenging in this environment.

Building Permits

The city saw a significant increase in residential building permits, up 91.03% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in building permits is a positive indicator for future affordability and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce, suggesting that the city is taking steps to address potential housing shortages and keep housing costs in check.

Days on Market

Homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue are currently sitting on the market for a median of 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.0%, placing it in the 92nd percentile. This slower market means that relocating workers may find it more accessible to find and purchase a home, as the market is not as competitive as those with faster turnover rates.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score ranking in the 72nd percentile, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's economy is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge workers but may be less ideal for those with primarily industrial or logistics-dominant needs.

In conclusion, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue offers a business environment with strong wage growth and an expanding housing supply, indicating a growing economy. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the city's below-average labor force growth, which could lead to challenges in finding and retaining talent in the future.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #21 OF 50

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.6th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	54
Unemployment	20% weight	58
Wage Growth	15% weight	94
Cost of Living	12% weight	14
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	20
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	12
Days on Market	5% weight	68
Office Economy	3% weight	70

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-23.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	45 days	median, +2.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.20%, and its high cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 13.92. The combination of these two metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Labor Demand

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.07% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.558% from its own trend. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for jobs but also a slight decrease in hours worked. This suggests that while the job market is growing, it may not be as robust as other metros.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.40%, which is near the median among US metros. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market with some slack, making it neither extremely tight nor extremely loose. For businesses trying to hire in this market, this means they may face some competition for talent, but it is still possible to find qualified candidates without excessive wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.20%, which is in the top tier among US metros. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have strong purchasing power. Businesses operating in this metro may need to budget for higher labor costs, but they can also expect a talented and productive workforce.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living percentile rank of 14th, indicating that it is one of the more expensive metros in the US. With a PSF to earnings ratio of 13.92 and a PSF decrease of -3.1% year-over-year, this city is relatively unaffordable compared to its peers. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living may be a deterrent for some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is shrinking at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. This could lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has decreased by 23.29% year-over-year. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This may pose a risk to businesses looking to attract and retain talent, as a tight housing market can make it difficult for workers to relocate.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.3%. This indicates a relatively slow market, with homes taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which could be an advantage.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has an office economy percentile rank of 70th, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This metro is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a talented and productive workforce, with strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool. However, the high cost of living and tightening housing market pose significant risks to businesses looking to attract and retain talent, and may require wage premiums and creative housing solutions to mitigate these challenges.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #22 OF 50

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	56
Unemployment	20% weight	54
Wage Growth	15% weight	38
Cost of Living	12% weight	2
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	82
Days on Market	5% weight	20
Office Economy	3% weight	66

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+22.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	53 days	median, -1.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low cost of living affordability, ranked at the 2nd percentile, and its above-average labor force growth rate of 1.23% YoY. The combination of a high cost of living ratio of 12.88 and a low affordability ranking signals significant challenges for talent attraction and retention.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is 0.68% YoY, with weekly hours deviating by 0.000% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.25, which ranks at the 56th percentile. This combination signals a near-median labor demand, indicating neither strong expansion nor contraction. The minimal deviation in weekly hours suggests a stable labor market, but the low employment growth rate may indicate some level of labor market slack.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.50%, ranking at the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but may not lead to significant wage pressure. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still indicates a competitive labor market, and businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this metro area is 2.82%, ranking at the 38th percentile, indicating below-average wage growth. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other metros. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, but at a slower rate than in other areas.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is relatively expensive, with a PSF of $522/sqft and an earnings ratio of 12.88, ranking at the 2nd percentile in terms of affordability. This low affordability ranking means that the city is less attractive for talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may offset higher wages. The 2.8% YoY increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability challenge.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of 1.23% YoY, ranking at the 74th percentile, indicating an above-average expansion of the workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the labor pool is increasing, providing a favorable environment for hiring and business expansion. As the labor force grows, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in this metro area has increased by 22.60% YoY, ranking at the 82nd percentile, indicating a strong expansion of housing supply. This increase in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for workers to relocate. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract talent in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this metro area is 53 days, with a YoY decrease of 1.9%, ranking at the 20th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The decreasing days on market further exacerbates the competitiveness of the market.

Office Economy

The office economy in this metro area is relatively deep, with a professional and office worker share ranking at the 66th percentile. This suggests that the city has a significant talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which may require a different type of workforce.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, but its high cost of living and relatively low wage growth rate pose significant challenges for talent attraction and retention. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this area is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain top talent, potentially offsetting the benefits of a growing labor force and expanding housing supply.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.2th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	42
Unemployment	20% weight	64
Wage Growth	15% weight	84
Cost of Living	12% weight	18
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	14
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	80
Days on Market	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	58

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+19.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, -13.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 6.15% year-over-year and its extremely low days on market for homes, currently at 39 days with a -13.3% year-over-year change. These metrics signal a highly competitive job market and a challenging housing market for relocating workers.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 0.60% year-over-year, combined with a -0.223% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.92, which ranks near the median at the 42nd percentile. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for jobs but not excessively high. The hours deviation being slightly below trend suggests that while jobs are being added, the existing workforce is not being overly stretched.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.20%, ranking at the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the limited availability of workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a strong local consumer demand due to the low unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 6.15%, placing it in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This fast wage growth indicates rising labor costs for employers but also signifies strong purchasing power for workers. As wages continue to rise, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living score that ranks at the 18th percentile, with a price per square foot of $629 and average hourly earnings of $50.11, resulting in a ratio of 12.55. The city is relatively expensive, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that the price per square foot has decreased by 4.8% year-over-year slightly mitigates this, but the overall affordability remains a concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has contracted by -1.59% year-over-year, ranking at the 14th percentile. This contraction indicates that the workforce supply is shrinking, posing a structural headwind for hiring and potentially exacerbating labor shortages in certain sectors.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has increased by 19.88% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This significant increase suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont currently sit on the market for a median of 39 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -13.3%, ranking at the 0th percentile. This extremely fast pace of home sales indicates a highly competitive housing market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a professional and office worker share that ranks at the 58th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors. The city is well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions but may not offer the same advantages for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented needs.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a highly competitive and innovative environment with strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the challenging housing market and high cost of living, which could significantly impact talent attraction and retention strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

Birmingham

Birmingham

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.9th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	74
Unemployment	20% weight	42
Wage Growth	15% weight	10
Cost of Living	12% weight	41
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	38
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	84
Days on Market	5% weight	40
Office Economy	3% weight	46

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+31.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	58 days	median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 48.9th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its above-average labor demand and top-tier building permit growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.82, driven by a 0.97% employment growth rate and a 0.164% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the 31.24% year-over-year increase in building permits suggests a strong developer confidence in the city's future.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of 0.97% and weekly hours deviation of 0.164% above its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours running above trend. This combination suggests that the city's labor market is experiencing a period of growth, driven by increasing demand for labor. The labor demand composite score of 5.82, ranking at the 74th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.70% ranks at the 42nd percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to indicate a highly competitive market, where wages might be driven up by intense competition for talent.

Wage Growth

Birmingham's year-over-year wage growth rate of 0.59% is relatively stagnant, ranking at the 10th percentile. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also means that workers' purchasing power is not growing quickly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have strong bargaining power either.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 4.93, based on $160 per square foot and $32.48 per hour, Birmingham ranks at the 41st percentile in terms of affordability. This near-median ranking suggests that the city is neither extremely affordable nor extremely expensive. The fact that the PSF is falling by 1.2% year-over-year relative to wages is a positive sign for affordability, but the overall cost of living is still a neutral factor in talent attraction.

Labor Force Growth

The city's labor force growth rate of -0.28% year-over-year indicates a contracting labor pool, ranking at the 38th percentile. This decline in the labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the available workforce is shrinking. This could lead to increased competition for workers and potentially drive up wages.

Building Permits

The 31.24% year-over-year increase in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, ranking at the 84th percentile. This top-tier growth in permits signals strong developer confidence in the city's future and implies that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve. As a result, businesses can expect a more favorable environment for attracting and retaining workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 58 days, with a 1.8% year-over-year increase, ranking at the 40th percentile. This near-median ranking suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow. For workers relocating to the city, this means that the market is accessible, but not overly competitive, making it relatively easier to find housing.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share of 2.42, ranking at the 46th percentile, Birmingham has a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for a variety of businesses, but may not be the best fit for those requiring a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers businesses a relatively stable labor market with above-average labor demand and top-tier building permit growth, suggesting a favorable environment for expansion. However, the city's slow wage growth and contracting labor force supply are significant risks that decision-makers should factor in, as they may lead to increased competition for workers and drive up labor costs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

Cleveland

Cleveland

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

47.9th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	36
Unemployment	20% weight	64
Wage Growth	15% weight	4
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	86
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	54
Days on Market	5% weight	72
Office Economy	3% weight	62

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+0.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 47.9th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its labor force growth and office economy. The city's labor force is expanding at a rate of 1.80% YoY, and its office economy is above average, with a 62nd percentile rank. These metrics suggest a city with a growing workforce and a deepening professional talent pool.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is 0.57% YoY, while its weekly hours deviation from trend is -0.437%, indicating a labor demand composite score of 4.66, which ranks below average at the 36th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The city's job market is not experiencing strong growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking above average at the 64th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. However, the unemployment rate is not extremely low, which could mitigate some wage pressure.

Wage Growth

Cleveland's wage growth is -0.32% YoY, ranking at the bottom tier with a 4th percentile score. This stagnant wage growth implies flat labor costs for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. The slow wage growth may not support strong worker purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $143/sqft to $33.82/hr, Cleveland ranks near the median at the 50th percentile. The city's cost of living is neither extremely affordable nor expensive, but the 13.5% YoY increase in PSF may erode affordability over time. This neutral cost of living score means that Cleveland does not have a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of 1.80% YoY, ranking at the top tier with an 86th percentile score. This expanding labor force supply implies a positive hiring capacity for businesses, as the workforce is increasing in size.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cleveland is increasing by 0.56% YoY, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate growth in housing supply suggests that affordability may improve slightly in the future, supporting workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cleveland is 55 days, with a 7.8% YoY increase, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, which may be more accessible for relocating workers. However, the rising DOM may also signal a normalization of the market rather than demand erosion.

Office Economy

Cleveland's office economy ranks above average at the 62nd percentile, indicating a deep professional talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers a growing labor force and a deepening professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for businesses seeking to tap into these resources. However, the city's stagnant wage growth and moderate cost of living may pose challenges for employer labor costs and talent attraction, respectively, and should be carefully considered by decision-makers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

47.4th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	78
Unemployment	20% weight	14
Wage Growth	15% weight	26
Cost of Living	12% weight	67
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	66
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	14
Days on Market	5% weight	48
Office Economy	3% weight	90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-22.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	54 days	median, +1.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 47.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 78th percentile, and its high cost of living, which ranks in the 67th percentile for affordability. The labor demand is driven by a 1.27% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.162% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has a labor demand composite score of 6.24, driven by a 1.27% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.162% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The strong labor demand indicates a healthy and growing job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.70%, ranking in the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 1.95%, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate is neither extremely high nor stagnant, suggesting that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. The moderate wage growth also means that worker purchasing power is increasing, but not at a rapid pace.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 67, driven by a PSF of $201/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $37.13/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.41. The PSF has decreased by 1.9% year-over-year, making the city more attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has grown by 0.73% year-over-year, ranking in the 66th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth in the labor force means that the hiring capacity for businesses is increasing, providing a larger pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has decreased by 22.31% year-over-year, ranking in the 14th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in building permits signals a potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 54 days, with a 1.9% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 48th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor accessible, for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.06, ranking in the 90th percentile, indicating a deep and specialized talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers a strong labor demand and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the declining number of residential building permits, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, potentially offsetting the city's current advantages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #27 OF 50

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.3th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	18
Unemployment	20% weight	34
Wage Growth	15% weight	44
Cost of Living	12% weight	16
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	98
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	92
Days on Market	5% weight	98
Office Economy	3% weight	52

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+67.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	46 days	median, +17.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth of 2.87% YoY and its high building permits growth of 67.46% YoY, indicating a expanding workforce and housing supply. However, its labor demand composite score of 3.82 ranks in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, suggesting a mismatch between job growth and hours worked.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 0.39% YoY, while weekly hours are deviating -1.026% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the modest job growth is not being accompanied by an increase in hours worked, suggesting a potential survivor squeeze. The labor demand composite score of 3.82 reinforces this interpretation, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking in the below-average tier at the 34th percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to suggest a significant surplus of workers, and businesses may still face some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.21%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. At the same time, workers are seeing some increase in their purchasing power, which could support local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living ratio of $474/sqft to $45.50/hr, with a percentile rank of 16th, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The PSF is falling -1.0% YoY, but this is not enough to offset the high absolute cost of living. As a result, businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living could be a deterrent for some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of 2.87% YoY, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This rapid expansion of the workforce supply suggests that businesses have a large and growing pool of potential workers to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of 67.46% YoY, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This rapid increase in housing supply suggests that the city is likely to see improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for workers in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is currently 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 17.9%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The top-tier percentile rank of 98th reinforces this interpretation, indicating a relatively slow and buyer-friendly market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 2.78, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors, making it suitable for businesses in tech, finance, and consulting. However, it may not be as well-suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a rapidly expanding workforce and housing supply, but also poses challenges due to its relatively high cost of living and moderate labor demand. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent in this expensive market, which could impact labor costs and profitability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.3th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	34
Unemployment	20% weight	24
Wage Growth	15% weight	68
Cost of Living	12% weight	80
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	44
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	38
Days on Market	5% weight	80
Office Economy	3% weight	2

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-6.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	52 days	median, +6.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.39, and its above-average wage growth, at 5.07% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends in wage growth but challenges in labor demand.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is 0.15% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.117% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend despite some job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.39 ranks below average, at the 34th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 4.20%, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, with some slack but not as much as in other cities. For a business trying to hire in this city, the practical implication is that it may be moderately challenging to find qualified candidates, with some upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is 5.07% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 68th percentile. This represents relatively fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but increased purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City has a cost of living score that ranks above average, at the 80th percentile, with a PSF-to-earnings ratio of $172/sqft to $33.58/hr, or 5.12. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums. The stable PSF growth, with a 0.0% year-over-year change, contributes to this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is growing at a rate of -0.04% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This indicates a slightly contracting labor pool, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Oklahoma City are decreasing at a rate of -6.14% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on employee relocation and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.1%, ranking at the 80th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can be accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also signal a normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share ranks at the 2nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a mixed economic environment with some positive trends in wage growth and affordability, but challenges in labor demand and a tightening housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential impact of a contracting labor pool and tightening housing supply on workforce accommodation and retention.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.9th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	52
Wage Growth	15% weight	70
Cost of Living	12% weight	78
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	10
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	90
Days on Market	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	34

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-2.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+53.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.20%. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.870% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and a decrease in working hours. This suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.10%, which is near the median, ranking 52nd percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the relatively higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.20%, which is above average, ranking 70th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score that ranks 78th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $305/sqft to $45.00/hr, which is 6.78. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -1.9% year-over-year further supports the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -1.70% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 10th percentile. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has increased by 53.15% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, ranking 90th percentile. This significant expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce, which can help attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%, ranking 74th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market for relocating workers, as homes are selling fairly quickly, but the rising DOM suggests a healthy normalization of the market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is below average, ranking 34th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, making it less suited for businesses that rely heavily on these sectors.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and relatively affordable cost of living, but it also poses significant challenges due to its weak labor demand and declining labor force supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's struggling labor market, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and hinder business expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #30 OF 50

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.7th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	76
Unemployment	20% weight	42
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	6
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	4
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	46
Days on Market	5% weight	52
Office Economy	3% weight	48

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**5.0%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.6%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.8%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**-2.2%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**-2.4%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**52 days**	median, +2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score of 5.96 ranking it in the 76th percentile, and its cost of living, which is in the bottom tier with a 6th percentile rank and a PSF to wages ratio of 15.94. The labor demand and cost of living metrics suggest a city with genuine job growth but significant affordability challenges.

Labor Demand

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an employment growth rate of +1.83% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.906% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score that signals genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.96 ranks in the 76th percentile, further supporting the notion of a robust job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 5.00%, ranking in the 42nd percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This rate suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to indicate a significant surplus of available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is +3.57%, ranking in the 50th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising at a moderate pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not at an exceptionally fast rate. The moderate wage growth may help attract and retain workers without putting excessive pressure on businesses.

Cost of Living

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has a cost of living score ranking it in the 6th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 15.94, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The PSF is $659/sqft, and it has decreased by -1.9% year-over-year, which slightly improves affordability. However, the city's low affordability score suggests that it may be challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is contracting at a rate of -2.24% year-over-year, ranking in the 4th percentile. This decline indicates that the workforce supply is shrinking, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. The contracting labor force may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has experienced a -2.43% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking in the 46th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to future affordability challenges and limitations on workforce accommodation. The slow growth in building permits may exacerbate the city's existing affordability issues.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.0%. This indicates a relatively stable housing market that is not excessively competitive, making it accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The moderate days on market suggest that the city's housing market is not overly pressured, which can be beneficial for businesses relocating employees.

Office Economy

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an office economy score ranking it in the 48th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and office skills, but may not be as attractive for businesses requiring highly specialized or abundant tech talent. The city's office economy is neither exceptionally strong nor weak, making it a viable option for a range of businesses.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers a strong labor market with genuine job growth, but it is constrained by significant affordability challenges and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent. Despite these challenges, the city's moderate wage growth and accessible housing market make it a viable option for businesses that can navigate its affordability issues.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.5th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	58
Unemployment	20% weight	62
Wage Growth	15% weight	28
Cost of Living	12% weight	63
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	6
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	26
Days on Market	5% weight	18
Office Economy	3% weight	56

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-14.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **51 days** median, -1.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 44.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, which is near median, and its labor force growth, which is in the bottom tier at -2.15% YoY. The combination of these metrics signals a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +0.60% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.147%. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the economy is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.90%, ranking at the 62nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +2.01%, which is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score ranking at the 63rd percentile, with a PSF of $284/sqft, which is decreasing by -3.1% YoY, and an hourly earnings rate of $42.34/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.71. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which is a talent attraction advantage, as businesses can attract workers without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -2.15% YoY, indicating a contracting labor supply. This implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is decreasing by -14.11% YoY, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 51 days, with a YoY decrease of -1.9%, ranking at the 18th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market for relocating workers, as homes are selling quickly.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is near median, ranking at the 56th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers, but may not be ideal for those requiring a highly specialized or technical workforce.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a tight labor market, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the shrinking labor force, which may limit hiring capacity and require businesses to offer competitive wages to attract talent. Overall, this city is a decent option for businesses looking to relocate or expand, but decision-makers should carefully consider the labor market challenges and plan accordingly.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C+

POOR

43.9th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	16
Unemployment	20% weight	68
Wage Growth	15% weight	24
Cost of Living	12% weight	22
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	80
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	64
Days on Market	5% weight	96
Office Economy	3% weight	28

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+9.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	35 days	median, +16.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its relatively low unemployment rate of 3.80%, ranking it in the 68th percentile. The labor demand and unemployment metrics suggest a complex labor market with both positive and negative signals.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.36% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.511% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for workers, but also may indicate a slower economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.80%, which is relatively low and ranks in the 68th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also suggests that workers may have some bargaining power, which could lead to upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.56%, which is below average and ranks in the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. Workers in the area may see some increase in purchasing power, but it may not be as strong as in other metros.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score that ranks in the 22nd percentile, with a PSF of $227/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.18/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.27. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The rising PSF (+1.8% YoY) suggests that the city may become even less affordable in the future, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +1.66% year-over-year, which is in the top tier and ranks in the 80th percentile. This expanding labor force supply suggests that businesses may have an easier time hiring workers in the future, as the pool of potential employees is growing.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +9.94% year-over-year, which is above average and ranks in the 64th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city may become more affordable in the future, making it easier for workers to relocate and for businesses to attract talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 35 days, with a year-over-year increase of +16.7%, ranking in the 96th percentile. This suggests a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a normalization of the housing market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Milwaukee-Waukesha is below average, ranking in the 28th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. However, the city may be more suited for businesses in industrial or logistics sectors.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a relatively low unemployment rate and an expanding labor force, but also presents challenges such as a low labor demand and a relatively expensive cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the potential for rising labor costs and decreasing affordability, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating the area as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #33 OF 50

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C+

POOR

41.7th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	8
Unemployment	20% weight	50
Wage Growth	15% weight	78
Cost of Living	12% weight	37
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	22
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	96
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	18

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+106.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 3.01 ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.91% in hourly earnings. These two metrics signal a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is -0.55% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.523%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.01 confirms this, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 4.00%, which is near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant tightness nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may not be overly challenging, but it also may not be particularly easy.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 5.91%, which is above average at the 78th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses operating in this city should be prepared for increasing labor expenses, but they can also expect a workforce with robust consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk has a cost of living score ranking it at the 37th percentile, indicating that it is below average in terms of affordability. With a PSF of $224/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.28/hr, the ratio is 6.35. This suggests that the city may not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively high compared to peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is contracting at a rate of -1.05% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may face challenges in finding and recruiting talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk has increased by 106.92% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This surge in building permits indicates that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. This is a positive signal for businesses considering relocation or expansion in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 39 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 26th percentile, suggests that relocating workers may face a competitive environment when searching for housing. However, the stable days on market indicates a balanced market without significant signs of overheating or cooling.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This indicates a less deep talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office or professional skills, making the city less suited for tech, finance, or consulting headquarters. However, it may be more accommodating to industries with different workforce requirements.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a complex economic environment with strong wage growth but weak labor demand and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the challenging labor market conditions, which may require strategic hiring and retention strategies to overcome. Despite these challenges, the city's expanding housing supply and relatively balanced labor market suggest opportunities for businesses that can adapt to the local economic character.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #34 OF 50

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

C+

POOR

41.6th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	28
Unemployment	20% weight	46
Wage Growth	15% weight	92
Cost of Living	12% weight	31
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	40
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	4
Days on Market	5% weight	24
Office Economy	3% weight	76

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+6.9%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-30.5%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
85 days
median, -3.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.93%, and its struggling labor demand, with a composite score of 4.29, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.18% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.262% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend during job growth, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 4.29 further reinforces this assessment, ranking below average at the 28th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced market with neither significant tightness nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the implication is that finding talent may not be overly challenging, but it also may not be exceptionally easy, with some wage pressure possible due to the moderate unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 6.93%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but also good worker purchasing power. Businesses locating here should anticipate a competitive labor market with upward pressure on wages.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score that ranks below average at the 31st percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $356/sqft to $34.40/hr, or 10.35. Although the PSF is falling by -0.8% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging, as the cost of living is not particularly advantageous.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This indicates a slightly contracting labor pool, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring, making it somewhat more difficult for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -30.46%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This significant decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.4%. This relatively fast market, with homes selling quickly, could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, potentially affecting a business's ability to attract and retain talent.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite ranking above average at the 76th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require a knowledgeable and specialized workforce. However, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach offers a complex economic environment with strong wage growth but challenges in labor demand and affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could exacerbate affordability issues and hinder workforce growth. Businesses must carefully weigh these factors when considering a location decision in this metro area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

C+

POOR

40.8th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	80
Unemployment	20% weight	10
Wage Growth	15% weight	34
Cost of Living	12% weight	49
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	2
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	18
Days on Market	5% weight	66
Office Economy	3% weight	84

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-19.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	67 days	median, -4.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 80th percentile ranking, and its low unemployment rate, which stands at 4.90%. The combination of these metrics suggests a competitive job market with genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +1.37% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.048% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. The labor demand composite score of 6.27 further reinforces this signal, indicating a strong and growing job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This low unemployment rate indicates a tight market with little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +2.39%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit slowly. While this may not be ideal for employers looking to keep costs low, it does indicate a relatively stable labor market.

Cost of Living

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a cost of living percentile rank of 49th, with a PSF of $267/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.40/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.14. This near-median ranking indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -1.5% year-over-year further supports this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is contracting at a rate of -2.70% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply indicates a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to be more aggressive in their recruitment efforts or consider alternative locations with growing labor forces.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is -19.67%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to factor in potential housing costs and availability when considering relocation or expansion in this market.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 67 days, with a year-over-year decline of -4.3%. This relatively fast market, with a percentile rank of 66th, indicates that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. However, this also suggests a competitive and active real estate market.

Office Economy

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge-economy talent. On the other hand, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force, which could lead to hiring challenges and upward pressure on wages. As a result, businesses should carefully consider their recruitment strategies and factor in potential labor market constraints when evaluating this location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #36 OF 50

Providence

Providence-Warwick

C+

POOR

40.6th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	46
Unemployment	20% weight	28
Wage Growth	15% weight	40
Cost of Living	12% weight	0
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	82
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	34
Days on Market	5% weight	78
Office Economy	3% weight	68

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-8.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	38 days	median, +2.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.17, ranking it at the 0th percentile for affordability. The labor demand composite score of 5.11, near the median at the 46th percentile, also plays a significant role in shaping the local economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.025% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate expansion in genuine demand, as the job market is growing, albeit slowly, and hours are not significantly above trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.11 reinforces this interpretation, indicating a near-median level of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking it at the 28th percentile, indicating a below-average level of unemployment. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with potential upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +3.00%, ranking it near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in the area are experiencing a modest increase in purchasing power, which could have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living percentile rank of 0, indicating that it is one of the most expensive cities relative to peers, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.17. The PSF is $367/sqft, which has increased by 8.6% year-over-year, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. This high cost of living may deter some companies from locating in the area, as they may need to compensate employees with higher salaries to maintain a comparable standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, ranking it at the 82nd percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses, as it indicates a growing pool of potential employees. As a result, companies may find it easier to hire and staff their operations in the area.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has decreased by -8.13% year-over-year, ranking it at the 34th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to increased competition for available housing and upward pressure on prices. This could have negative implications for future affordability and workforce accommodation in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is currently 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.7%. This ranks the city at the 78th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to the city, this slower market may be beneficial, as it provides more time to find and secure housing. However, it may also signal a weakening demand for housing, which could have broader implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy percentile rank of 68, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. The city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for companies in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

In conclusion, Providence-Warwick offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and a deep talent pool in professional sectors. However, the city's high cost of living and tightening housing supply are significant constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating the area as a potential location for their business. The single biggest risk is the potential for upward pressure on wages and housing costs, which could erode the city's competitiveness and make it challenging for businesses to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

C+

POOR

39.4th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	60
Unemployment	20% weight	6
Wage Growth	15% weight	22
Cost of Living	12% weight	57
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	70
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	24
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-14.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 60th percentile, and its high unemployment rate, which stands at 5.20% and ranks in the 6th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a mixed economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.14% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.342%. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs, albeit with hours slightly below trend. This indicates a moderate level of labor demand, with some room for growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 5.20%, ranking in the 6th percentile, which indicates a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire, but also potentially weakening local consumer demand. As a result, businesses may face less wage pressure when hiring in this city.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.52%, which ranks in the 22nd percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $171/sqft to $36.01/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 2.3% in PSF, this city ranks in the 57th percentile for affordability. This means that Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of 0.88% year-over-year, which ranks in the 70th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -14.66%, which ranks in the 24th percentile, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and potential constraints on workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with no year-over-year change. This indicates a relatively stable housing market, which is neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible for relocating workers. However, the lack of change in days on market suggests a balanced market, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.28, ranking in the 78th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a mixed economic environment, with a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding labor force, but also a high unemployment rate and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the potential for future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints due to the tightening housing supply, which could impact talent attraction and retention efforts.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

C+

POOR

39.1th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	32
Unemployment	20% weight	18
Wage Growth	15% weight	2
Cost of Living	12% weight	69
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	68
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	70
Days on Market	5% weight	70
Office Economy	3% weight	54

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+15.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	63 days	median, -12.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.80% and its negative wage growth rate of -0.68%, which signal a challenging labor market for businesses. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 4.39, ranking in the 32th percentile, and the low wage growth rate are key metrics that shape the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Jacksonville is +0.33% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.372% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend during job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.39, ranking in the 32th percentile, further supports this conclusion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.80%, ranking in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the market is not overly saturated with job seekers, but there is still some availability of talent. The tight market implies potential wage pressure for businesses trying to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Jacksonville is -0.68%, ranking in the 2th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The stagnant wage growth may make it challenging for businesses to attract top talent, as workers may seek better compensation packages elsewhere.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score ranking in the 69th percentile, with a PSF of $216/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.43/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.93. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, as the PSF is falling -3.1% year-over-year. The affordability of Jacksonville can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of +0.78% year-over-year, ranking in the 68th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which can be beneficial for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force can provide a larger pool of potential employees, reducing the challenges associated with hiring in a tight labor market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Jacksonville is increasing by +15.03% year-over-year, ranking in the 70th percentile. This rise in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. The increasing housing supply can help to mitigate potential workforce attraction and retention challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is currently 63 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -12.5%, ranking in the 70th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly. For workers relocating to Jacksonville, this means that the housing market can be competitive, and they may need to act rapidly to secure a home.

Office Economy

Jacksonville has an office economy score ranking in the 54th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers of 2.86. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional roles. While Jacksonville may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce, it can still support a range of industries, including those with more balanced workforce requirements.

The city of Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding labor force, which can be beneficial for talent attraction and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in Jacksonville is the challenging labor market, characterized by low unemployment and stagnant wage growth, which can lead to wage pressure and difficulties in hiring top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

C+

POOR

38.6th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	64
Unemployment	20% weight	30
Wage Growth	15% weight	6
Cost of Living	12% weight	45
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	24
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	62
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	14

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.0%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+9.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **38 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 38.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 64th percentile, and its stagnant wage growth, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.46% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.718% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has a labor demand composite score of 5.63, driven by a 1.46% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.718% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth. The labor market is adding jobs, but the slight decline in hours worked suggests a moderate pace of expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.40%, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it slightly easier to hire in this market compared to tighter labor markets. However, the relatively higher unemployment rate compared to other metros may also imply weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is a stagnant +0.01%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score in the 45th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $208/sqft to $39.46/hr, or 5.27. The city's cost of living is near the median, neither extremely affordable nor expensive. This means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but the city does not have a strong talent attraction advantage due to affordability either.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is contracting at a -0.97% year-over-year rate, ranking in the 24th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +9.15%, ranking in the 62nd percentile. This increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 38 days, with a 0% year-over-year change, ranking in the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market for relocating workers, as homes are selling quickly.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington ranks in the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a labor market with moderate demand expansion and a relatively slow pace of wage growth, which can help control labor costs. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor force, which may pose challenges for hiring and talent acquisition in the long term.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

Fresno

Fresno

C

VERY POOR

36.4th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	44
Unemployment	20% weight	0
Wage Growth	15% weight	80
Cost of Living	12% weight	47
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	12
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	36
Days on Market	5% weight	42
Office Economy	3% weight	30

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
7.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+6.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-6.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
55 days
median, +1.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.04, near the median. The city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 5.96% and its low unemployment rate of 7.70%, which is actually a concern as it ranks at the 0th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. These metrics suggest a complex labor environment with both opportunities and challenges.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 1.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -2.051% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate expansion in job numbers but with hours worked below trend, which may indicate some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.04, near the median, further supports this nuanced view.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.70%, ranking at the 0th percentile, which means the labor market is extremely tight. This tightness implies that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is very small, leading to potential wage pressure. For a business trying to hire in Fresno, this means preparing for a highly competitive hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Fresno is 5.96%, placing it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This fast wage growth indicates rising labor costs for employers but also suggests strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should anticipate higher payroll costs but also a workforce with increased disposable income, potentially benefiting local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score near the median at the 47th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $263/sqft to $33.62/hr, equating to 7.82. This suggests that Fresno is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. For talent attraction, this means that businesses may not gain a significant advantage in terms of cost of living alone, as wage premiums might still be necessary to attract top talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is shrinking at a rate of -1.69% year-over-year, ranking at the 12th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses should consider this trend when planning for future staffing needs, as it may limit their ability to expand or replace personnel.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Fresno is -6.89%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This decline indicates that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend signals potential risks for businesses reliant on a mobile workforce or looking to attract talent from other areas.

Days on Market

Homes in Fresno are currently sitting on the market for 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.9%. This moderate days on market figure, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile, suggests a relatively balanced market. For workers relocating to Fresno, this means the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible, offering a somewhat normalized environment for home buying.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This indicates a less deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses requiring a high concentration of tech, finance, consulting, or HQ functions. However, it might be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The city of Fresno presents a mixed bag for businesses, offering fast wage growth and a tight labor market but also facing challenges such as a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the tight labor market and its implications for hiring and wage costs, which could significantly impact business operations and profitability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C

VERY POOR

36.3th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	24
Unemployment	20% weight	32
Wage Growth	15% weight	86
Cost of Living	12% weight	43
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	8
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	32
Days on Market	5% weight	38
Office Economy	3% weight	0

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-9.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	61 days	median, -1.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and mediocre labor demand. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of 6.17% year-over-year and its below-average labor demand composite score of 4.00, which signals a mix of job growth and hours contraction. These metrics suggest a complex labor market with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 0.65% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.215% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a labor demand composite score of 4.00. This combination signals a scenario where job growth is present, but hours are not expanding as much as expected, which may indicate some level of survivor squeeze. The labor market is not as strong as the employment growth rate alone would suggest.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.30%, which is below average, ranking 32nd percentile. This indicates a moderately tight labor market with some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to very tight markets. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to suggest significant wage pressure or intense competition for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 6.17%, which is in the top tier, ranking 86th percentile. This fast wage growth suggests rising labor costs for employers, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand. Businesses should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score of 43rd percentile, with a PSF of $333/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.56/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.36. The city's PSF is falling -1.8% year-over-year, which contributes to its near-median affordability score. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 8th percentile. This indicates a shrinking labor pool, presenting a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. The declining labor force supply will make it challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is -9.60%, which is below average, ranking 32nd percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The reduction in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a readily available and affordable housing supply for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 61 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.6%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, although not extremely competitive. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is somewhat accessible, but the declining days on market suggests a trend towards a more competitive environment.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a very shallow professional talent pool, ranking 0th percentile in terms of office and professional worker share. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more appropriate for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and relatively affordable living costs, but it also presents significant challenges, including a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the declining labor force supply, which will require careful planning and strategic recruitment efforts to overcome.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

C

VERY POOR

36.0th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	24
Wage Growth	15% weight	76
Cost of Living	12% weight	74
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	28
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	56
Days on Market	5% weight	46
Office Economy	3% weight	8

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-2.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+2.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	57 days	median, +3.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.0th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its weak labor demand and limited office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining a -2.07% employment growth rate and a -0.245% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in job opportunities. Additionally, the low office/professional worker share of 0.68, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, defines the city's economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -2.07% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.245% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario points to a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or hire.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.00%, ranking below average at the 24th percentile, indicating some slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is not a significant surplus of workers, which could lead to moderate wage pressure. Businesses trying to hire in this market may face some competition for talent, but it is not as intense as in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is +5.82%, ranking above average at the 76th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests rising labor costs for employers but also strong purchasing power for workers. Businesses operating in this market should be prepared for higher labor costs but can also expect a workforce with increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score that ranks above average at the 74th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $306/sqft to $42.08/hr, or 7.27, and the PSF is falling -2.2% year-over-year. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without needing wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability, making the city more attractive for workers and businesses alike.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -0.81% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the workforce is shrinking, presenting a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses looking to grow in this market may face challenges in finding sufficient talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is increasing by +2.48% year-over-year, which is near the median. This growth in permits signals an expansion in future housing supply, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the moderate pace of growth may not be enough to significantly impact the current affordability landscape.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.6%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which could be more accessible for relocating workers. However, the market is still relatively competitive, and workers may face some challenges in finding and securing housing.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 0.68, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a shallow talent pool in these areas. This city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a workforce with strong purchasing power due to high wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the weak labor demand and contracting labor force, which could significantly hinder hiring and expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

C

VERY POOR

34.0th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	12
Unemployment	20% weight	12
Wage Growth	15% weight	20
Cost of Living	12% weight	94
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	54
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	58
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	60

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.8%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+1.3%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+5.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
65 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34th out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its low labor demand and high cost of living affordability. The labor demand composite score of 3.65, combining a +0.61% employment growth rate and a -2.35% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a weak labor market. The cost of living, with a PSF of $172/sqft and a ratio of 5.29 to hourly earnings of $32.51, ranks in the top tier for affordability, at the 94th percentile.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.61% and weekly hours deviation of -2.35% from trend indicate a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a slight increase in jobs without corresponding increases in hours worked. This combination suggests that while there are some new jobs being added, the existing workforce is not seeing significant increases in their workloads. The labor demand composite score of 3.65 is in the bottom tier, at the 12th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.80% indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight. This means that businesses trying to hire in this market may have an easier time finding candidates, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The unemployment rate ranks in the bottom tier, at the 12th percentile.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.33% is below average, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The wage growth rate ranks below average, at the 20th percentile.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $172/sqft and a ratio of 5.29 to hourly earnings of $32.51, is highly affordable, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live here without requiring significant wage premiums. The PSF is also falling by -4.4% year-over-year, making the city even more affordable.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.23% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This means that the hiring capacity in the city is increasing, but only slightly. The labor force growth rate ranks near the median, at the 54th percentile.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +5.83%, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is increasing, and future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve. The building permits growth rate ranks near the median, at the 58th percentile.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 65 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%. This indicates a relatively slow market, where homes are sitting for a moderate amount of time before being sold. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is relatively accessible, but not extremely competitive.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.98, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy roles, but may not be as suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a highly affordable cost of living and a slowly expanding workforce supply, but also presents a risk of weak labor demand and moderate wage growth. The single biggest constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the city's low labor demand, which may limit the growth potential of businesses that require a highly skilled and dynamic workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

C

VERY POOR

34.0th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	4
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	0
Cost of Living	12% weight	8
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	52
Days on Market	5% weight	82
Office Economy	3% weight	18

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-1.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-0.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	47 days	median, +4.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34th out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, at -1.33% employment growth YoY and -0.71% wage growth, respectively. The city's economic character is also marked by a tight labor market, with an unemployment rate of 3.40%, and a relatively expensive cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 5.07. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.33% YoY, while weekly hours are deviating 0.298% above the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine expansion. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 2.14 is in the bottom tier, at the 4th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.40%, which is in the top tier, at the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The tight labor market implies that hiring will be challenging, with potential wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -0.71%, which is in the bottom tier, at the 0th percentile, indicating stagnant or even declining wages. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers will be flat, but worker purchasing power will be weak. The stagnant wage growth also suggests that the city may not be attractive to workers seeking better compensation.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score in the bottom tier, at the 8th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 5.07, driven by a PSF of $166/sqft that is rising 4.4% YoY, outpacing earnings growth. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it difficult to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living may deter some businesses from locating in the city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is growing at a rate of 0.22% YoY, which is near the median, at the 50th percentile. This slow growth rate implies that the labor force supply is expanding, but only marginally, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid hiring or business expansion. The moderate labor force growth suggests that businesses may need to invest in training and development to build the skills they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is declining at a rate of -0.22% YoY, which is near the median, at the 52nd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city. The slow permit growth implies that the city may face challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 47 days, with a YoY increase of 4.4%, which is in the top tier, at the 82nd percentile. This means that the housing market is slowing down, with homes taking longer to sell, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The rising days on market suggests a more balanced market, with less pressure on prices.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively low, with a composite score of 1.44, ranking in the bottom tier, at the 18th percentile. This suggests that the city has a shallow talent pool for businesses that require specialized office or professional skills, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms. The city's economy is more geared towards industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with low unemployment, but also presents challenges such as stagnant wage growth, a high cost of living, and a shallow professional talent pool. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent, particularly in specialized office or professional roles, due to the city's expensive cost of living and limited labor force growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

Richmond

Richmond

C-

CRITICAL

31.4th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	10
Unemployment	20% weight	56
Wage Growth	15% weight	36
Cost of Living	12% weight	20
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	30
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	60
Days on Market	5% weight	2
Office Economy	3% weight	26

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+8.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	40 days	median, -7.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.80%. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 3.05 and the unemployment rate of 3.80% are the key metrics that shape the city's current economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.72% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.245%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth. The positive deviation in weekly hours suggests a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.80%, which is near the median, ranking 56th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the tight market means it may be harder to find qualified candidates, and there may be upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +2.59%, which is below average, ranking 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may be a concern for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score ranking it 20th percentile, with a PSF of $229/sqft and an earnings ratio of $35.37/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.47. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising by 1.8% year-over-year relative to wages makes it even less affordable. This may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is shrinking at a rate of -0.80% year-over-year, ranking 30th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that the hiring capacity for businesses may be limited, making it harder to find qualified candidates.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond is increasing by 8.22% year-over-year, ranking 60th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is 40 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -7.0%, ranking 2nd percentile. This indicates a highly competitive market where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Richmond has a professional and office worker share ranking it 26th percentile, with a composite score of 1.70. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Richmond metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but it also presents challenges such as a shrinking labor force and a competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited hiring capacity due to the contracting labor force supply, which may hinder business growth and expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

C-

CRITICAL

30.6th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	30
Unemployment	20% weight	48
Wage Growth	15% weight	16
Cost of Living	12% weight	12
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	16
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	74
Days on Market	5% weight	6
Office Economy	3% weight	12

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+16.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	46 days	median, -6.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.38, and its stagnant wage growth, at +1.15% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.69% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.889% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. Instead, the slight job growth is accompanied by a decrease in hours worked, suggesting a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.80%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively moderate unemployment rate also implies that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.15%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This stagnant wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face strong upward pressure on wages, but they may also struggle to attract and retain top talent due to the limited growth in earnings.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $344/sqft to $37.97/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.06. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising +0.3% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.39% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that the city's hiring capacity is shrinking, posing a structural headwind for businesses looking to expand their workforce. As the labor pool contracts, companies may face increasing competition for a dwindling number of qualified candidates.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is increasing by +16.17% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future affordability may improve. As a result, the city's workforce accommodation and attractiveness to relocating workers may also increase, mitigating some of the pressure on the labor market.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is currently 46 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -6.1%. This rapid pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The low days on market percentile rank of 6th percentile further emphasizes the intensity of the market, suggesting that workers may need to act quickly to secure a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in knowledge-economy sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or headquarters operations. Instead, the city's economy may be more dominant in industrial or logistics sectors, which could be a better fit for companies operating in those fields.

In conclusion, Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom offers a mixed bag for businesses, with some positives such as expanding housing supply and moderate unemployment. However, the city's low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and high cost of living pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support business expansion and growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #47 OF 50

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C-

CRITICAL

28.5th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	22
Unemployment	20% weight	2
Wage Growth	15% weight	14
Cost of Living	12% weight	29
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	94
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	28
Days on Market	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	38

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-11.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 28.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.96 ranking it at the 22nd percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 5.40%, which ranks it at the 2nd percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.24% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.219% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a pace that would suggest genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be experiencing a period of payroll contraction.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.40%, ranking it at the 2nd percentile, which means the market has significant slack. This implies that businesses trying to hire in this city may find it easier to staff, but they may also face weaker local consumer demand due to the high number of unemployed individuals.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.06%, ranking it at the 14th percentile, which indicates stagnant wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly, which could impact consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score ranking it at the 29th percentile, with a PSF of $186/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.54/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.09. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +2.68% year-over-year, ranking it at the 94th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has decreased by -10.99% year-over-year, ranking it at the 28th percentile. This signals that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.6%, ranking it at the 74th percentile. This suggests a slower market, which could make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn ranks at the 38th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city may be better suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, rather than tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a relatively slow housing market, but it also poses significant challenges, including low labor demand and high unemployment. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's tight housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it difficult to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #48 OF 50

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

C-

CRITICAL

27.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	20
Unemployment	20% weight	70
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	10
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	0
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	22
Days on Market	5% weight	8
Office Economy	3% weight	10

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-8.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-15.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	37 days	median, -5.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 27.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 3.84, ranking it in the 20th percentile, and its cost of living ratio of 6.81, which places it in the 10th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.33% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.923% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a pace that would suggest genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be experiencing a period of payroll contraction.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.20%, which ranks it in the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. As a result, wage pressure is likely to be higher in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +2.03%, which is below average and ranks it in the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. However, worker purchasing power is also increasing, which could have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living ratio of 6.81, with a PSF of $221/sqft and average hourly earnings of $32.46/hr. The city's cost of living percentile rank is 10th, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living could be a deterrent for workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -8.76% year-over-year, which ranks it in the 0th percentile. This significant decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find the talent they need to expand or maintain operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has decreased by -15.25% year-over-year, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of housing is not expanding to meet demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -5.1%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing options.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 0.74, ranking it in the 10th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but its high cost of living and declining labor force supply pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor pool, which could limit hiring capacity and make it difficult to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

C-

CRITICAL

27.2th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	40
Unemployment	20% weight	8
Wage Growth	15% weight	46
Cost of Living	12% weight	26
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	34
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	6
Days on Market	5% weight	12
Office Economy	3% weight	32

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
5.3%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+3.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.5%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-28.6%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
35 days
median, -2.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 27.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 5.30% and its stagnant labor force growth rate of -0.53% YoY. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.12% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.375% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a slow one, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.84 ranks near the median at the 40th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 5.30%, ranking it at the 8th percentile, indicating a significant amount of slack in the labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will have an easier time finding candidates, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The low unemployment percentile rank suggests that the market is not tight, and wage pressure may be relatively low.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.22%, ranking it near the median at the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. However, the wage growth rate is not fast enough to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living percentile rank of 26th, with a PSF of $221/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.09/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.96. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, ranking below average in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is rising +2.8% YoY relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability issue, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -0.53% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction suggests that hiring capacity may be limited, and businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to expand their workforce. The below-average labor force growth rate ranks at the 34th percentile.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is -28.57%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This suggests that the city's housing market may be tightening, which could lead to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The low ranking at the 6th percentile raises concerns about future affordability and workforce attraction.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 35 days, with a year-over-year decline of -2.8%. This relatively fast market suggests that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. The low percentile rank of 12th indicates a competitive market, which may be a concern for businesses trying to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin ranks at the 32nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost labor market with moderate wage growth, but its high unemployment rate, stagnant labor force growth, and tightening housing market pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential affordability issue and the limited availability of specialized office talent, which may hinder the city's attractiveness to certain types of businesses.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

D

EMERGENCY

18.7th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	6
Unemployment	20% weight	2
Wage Growth	15% weight	18
Cost of Living	12% weight	33
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	46
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	8
Days on Market	5% weight	94
Office Economy	3% weight	4

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-27.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	43 days	median, +10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 18.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.57. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high unemployment rate, with employment growth at -0.47% year-over-year and an unemployment rate of 5.20%. These metrics signal significant challenges for businesses looking to hire and expand in the area.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.47% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 1.071% above the city's own 12-month trend. However, the combination of these metrics signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze. This suggests that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 5.20%, which is relatively high, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. With an unemployment rate ranking in the 2nd percentile, the market is not tight, and businesses may not face significant wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.17%, which is relatively slow. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. With a wage growth rank in the 18th percentile, the city's wage environment is not particularly favorable for businesses looking to attract top talent.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score ranking in the 33rd percentile, with a PSF of $178/sqft and average hourly earnings of $30.70/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.80. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The stable YoY change in PSF (+0.0%) suggests that the city's affordability is not deteriorating. This makes it easier for businesses to attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is growing at a rate of +0.08% year-over-year, which is near the median. This slow growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, but only slightly. While this is a positive sign for hiring capacity, the slow growth rate may still pose some challenges for businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by -27.55% year-over-year. This sharp decline signals that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges for workforce accommodation. With a building permits rank in the 8th percentile, the city's housing market is not favorable for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.3%. This relatively slow pace of home sales, ranking in the 94th percentile, indicates a buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may have more time to find a home, making the city more accessible.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.44, ranking in the 4th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slow pace of home sales, making it accessible for workers to relocate. However, the city's low labor demand, high unemployment rate, and slow wage growth pose significant challenges for businesses looking to hire and expand in the area, making it a high-risk location for investment.